

Fake or Masterpiece? Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • The Arts • 25-35 min

Category	The Arts	Time	25-35 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	fake-or-masterpiece

Big idea: Reputation affects judgement.

Overview

Students test how reputation, authorship and context shape aesthetic judgement.

Student Prompt

Inspect Fake or Masterpiece? Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Fake or Masterpiece? Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Two artworks with different provenance stories but similar visual quality. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Fake or Masterpiece? Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A value ranking before and after learning authorship. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Fake or Masterpiece? Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A debrief on whether knowledge about origin changes aesthetic knowledge. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Reputation affects judgement.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Fake or Masterpiece? Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Fake or Masterpiece? Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Is artistic value in the object, the viewer or the culture?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how reputation affects judgement.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: Two artworks with different provenance stories but similar visual quality.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Two artworks with different provenance stories but similar visual quality.
- A value ranking before and after learning authorship.
- A debrief on whether knowledge about origin changes aesthetic knowledge.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Students rank artworks by artistic value without context.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Reveal partial context: artist, date, price, AI-generated or not, museum status.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Students revise rankings and explain why.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Discuss whether context is part of the artwork.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat interpretation as purely subjective and therefore beyond evidence.
- Students may ignore how context, form, and audience knowledge constrain readings.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Supports interpretation with formal features, context, and audience response.
- Explains why multiple readings are not automatically equal.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Short lesson: use only the first example, one response grid, and one debrief question.
- Long lesson: add a second round where students revise the method and compare outcomes.
- Low-tech option: run with printed cards, sticky notes, and a board tally.

Extension Tasks

- Design a second version of the activity that tests the same knowledge issue in another AOK.
- Find a real-world example where the same knowledge problem matters outside the classroom.
- Write a 150-word TOK exhibition-style commentary using the activity as the object context.

Related Activities

- Title Changes Meaning
- One Image, Many Readings
- Music and Emotion Experiment